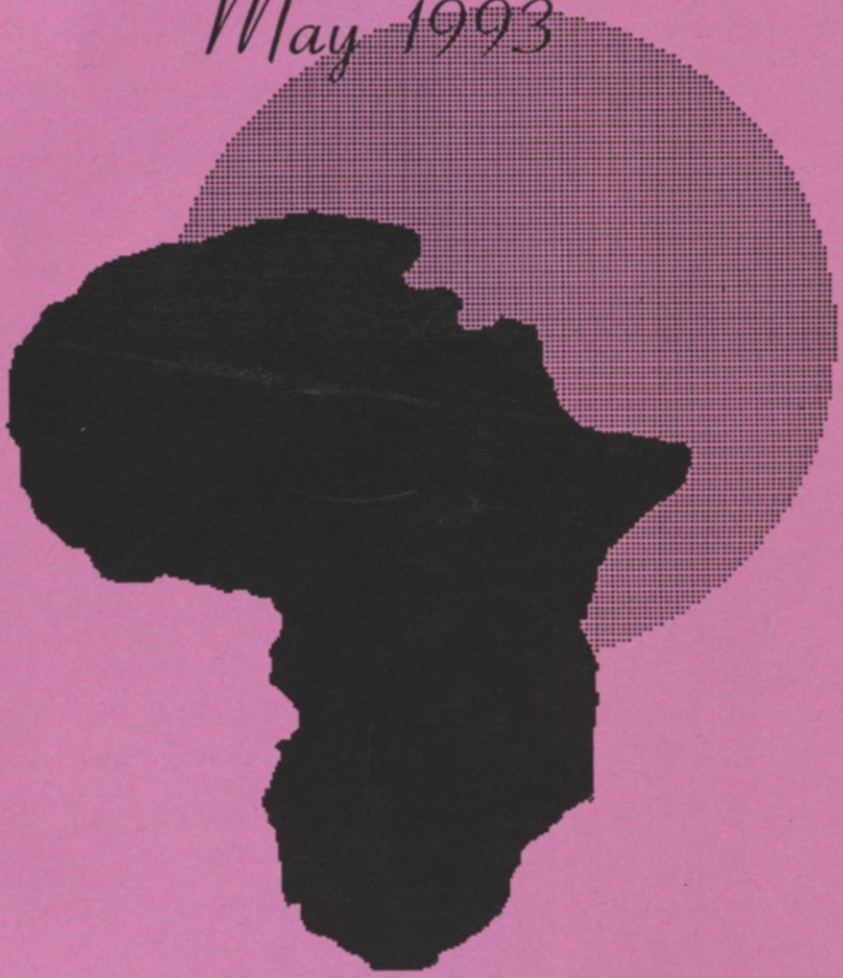
African Sun

May 1993



To the Sisters and Brothers of the Class of 1993:

It is with sadness and joy that we bid you farewell and best wishes. As you prepare for your future endeavors, please remember the valuable lessons that the Brown experience has taught you. Remember that you were dubbed "the Mistake" when you entered, as you were "mistakenly" accepted into Brown on need-blind terms. Remember the personal and political battles which challenged your beliefs, your relationships, and your selfhood. And never forget those who came before you, those who are still here, and those who are yet to come. As you climb the ladder of success, do not neglect your responsibility to pull others up with you as you climb, for if you lose sight of your community, you will ultimately lose yourself as well. Stay Black, Beautiful, & Strong. Good luck in all of your future endeavors.

—The *African Sun* Staff

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Libero Della Piana
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Gerald R. Taylor
Nathaniel H. Taylor
Terrence O. Taylor
Ranice E. Thompson
Lori A. Todd
Jacqueline T. Wigfall
Eder J. Williams
Victor E. Williams
Kobi M. Wright
Tahesha Wright

The 1993 AKA Image Awards

Most Artistic:	Rod Bowen	Nicole Brewer
Best Dressed:	Chris Gordon	Angelique Anderson
Most Afrocentric:	Terrence Taylor	Michelle Hester
Most Attractive:	David Hirsch	Tahesha Wright
Best Body:	Bruce Strothers	Allyson Hall, Jenn Lee, Kimani Paul-Emile
Sexiest:	Gerald Taylor	A. Danine Lard
Most Studious:	David Hirsch	Nicole Jackson
Most Flirtatious:	Gerald Taylor	Melanie Jones
Most Athletic:	Kiilu Davis	Margaret Crumety
Biggest Party Animal:	Erwin Salomon	Kerri Barbour, Nicole Brewer
Friendliest:	Lome Aseron	Linda Smith, Eder Williams
Best Brunonian:	Warren Brown	Jennifer Lee
Most Likely to Succed:	Brickson Diamond	Eleanor Brown
Classiest:	Eric Parrish	Kenya Crumel, Tahesha Wright
Best Personality:	Gerald Taylor	Heather Gray
Most Visible:	Chris Gordon Erwin Salomon	Nicole Brewer
Shadiest:	Erwin Salomon	Regine Ostine
Most Service-Oriented	Libero Della Piana	Jennifer Lee
Best Smile:	Gerald Taylor	Clair Chester

Historical Events

1, 1867 - Howard University opens in Washington, D.C.

1, 1950 - Author Gwendolyn Brooks receives the Pulitzer Prize for poetry.

3, 1845 - Macon B. Allen, the first Black American to be formally admitted to a bar association, passes the bar examination in Worcester, MA.

2, 1968 - Black students seize the Finance Building of Northwestern University in demand for Black-oriented curricular offerings and campus reforms.

4, 1961 - Thirteen "Freedom Riders" embark on a bus trip through the South. The bus with the first group of Freedom Riders is bombed and burned by segregationists in Anniston, AL on May 14, and another mob attacks the Freedom Riders in Montgomery on May 20. Attorney General Robert F. Kennedy dispatches 400 U.S. marshals to Montgomery on May 20 to restore order, and Governor Patterson declares martial law in Montgomery and calls out the National Guard on May 21.

10, 1775 - Black patriots participate in the first aggressive action of American forces in the Revolutionary War—the capture of Fort Ticonderoga.

18, 1896 - The Supreme Court's decision in *Plessy v. Ferguson* upholds the "separate but equal" doctrine.

22, 1948 - Author Claude McKay, one of the leading figures in the Harlem Renaissance, dies. Among his works were *Home to Harlem* and "If We Must Die."

27, 1958 - Robert N.C. Nix graduates from Little Rock's Central High School with 600 white classmates.

30, 1822 - A house slave betrays the Denmark Vessey conspiracy, one of the most elaborate slave plots on record, involving thousands of Blacks in the Charleston, S.C. area. Authorities arrest 131 Blacks and 4 whites; 37 are hanged.

Campus News

Brown Sisters Rise to the Occasion

Hours of planning, fundraising, and rehearsing finally paid off as Brown Sisters United presented "And Still I Rise: A Celebration of Black Women." The event, which took place in Alumnae Hall on Sat., May 1, showcased the talents of Black women at Brown through monologues, dance routines, and song performances. Coordinators of the event were Dawn Adams '93, Angelique Anderson '93, Heather Gray '93, Nina Guercio '93, Kehli Harding '94, A. Danine Lard '93, and Lynette Sumpter '94. Among the performances were a dance routine titled "Free Your Mind," which challenged the dominant images of women in hip-hop videos, and the grand finale performance of "I'm Every Woman." *You go, ladies!*

Black Folks Seize Pembroke Fieldhouse During Spring Weekend!

On April 24, OUAP sponsored its annual Spring Weekend Umoja Barbeque, this year at the Pembroke Fieldhouse. As in previous years, the Umoja Barbeque was one of the few Black-oriented events to take place on campus during Spring Weekend, a time when most of the campus's festivities occur on Wriston Quad. The barbeque included chicken, sodas, volleyball and football, music by D.J. Dirk, Black people, and good times for all who attended.

The Alpha Cabaret

Following the festive spirit of the Umoja BBQ was an evening of elegance and entertainment as Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity, Inc. sponsored its annual Spring Weekend Cabaret. Held at the Cranston Yacht Club, the Cab included dinner, dancing, and a performance by comedian Dante Carter, who has appeared on HBO's *Def Comedy Jam.*

Africa House needs books, artwork, etc.
Call Khary (x4556) or Joelle (x6271) if you have donations

Thoughts & Opinions

The views expressed in this section are independent of the *African Sun*. The purpose of Thoughts & Opinions is to provide a forum for Black students to discuss issues which affect the Black community at Brown and beyond. Please keep this in mind as you read.

Using Hip-Hop Culture as Criteria for Blackness at Brown

Many Black people on this campus come from predominately white institutions and/or have parents who are not even from the United States, yet now that they are here at Brown, they can be Black. My question is, weren't you Black when you were born? Did Brown make you Blacker? We as Black people complain when white people capitalize on Black culture, but what about those Black people who come to Brown, and all of a sudden pick up this hip-hop lingo and attitude? You've seen this attitude, it is the *you-go-girl, head-twirling, rap-video-copying, talking-in-latest-hip-hop-parables...*

Now if someone wants to be a hip-hopper or is coming from a neighborhood in which hip-hop culture is the norm, nothing is wrong with that. Black culture is multifaceted, and hip-hop culture is one of the many cultures that can be associated with Black people. Hip-hop culture should be given its respect because it is a legitimate culture reflective of urban Black America. But when hip-hop criteria are used to judge the Blackness of those of African descent, that is when it can take a dangerous and destructive turn; and unfortunately Black people do that on this campus. These hip-hop criteria for judging Blackness are dangerous because they set up a status quo in defining who is Black and who is not. "You either talk the talk, dance the dance, move your hands in a certain way, listen to the music, wear the baggy jeans, twist your hair, watch *In Living Color* and *Martin*, etc.," or get accused of not being Black enough unless you were not born in this country. This type of thinking assumes that for Black people you either fit into the mold or become the non-entity. This is also dismaying because using this judgment as criteria is hypocritical for those Black people who really do not come from the "hood," and know they are perpetrating a false act, and it is arrogant for those who really are from the "hood" who see their culture as being the only authentic Black culture. There is no authentic Black culture, because there are too many Black cultures to pinpoint any one as being the only authentic one. And Black means several things to different people. If there were a spaghetti strainer test for judging this Blackness by hip-hopness, then sooner or later those of you who are faking would be counted out as not being Black.

Black culture all over the world is diverse, which is why some African Americans who go abroad to predominately Black countries may suffer from culture shock, because even though they are Black they do not fit in. Not fitting in is not particularly an endearing feeling.

I am not implying that hip-hoppers subscribe to superficial acts in public. But some of you who are so into this culture have no clue at all about the very basis of this hip-hop culture you are trying to imitate. Someone who really comes from an urban Black neighborhood may see nothing glamorous in hip-hop culture because it is a reality and a way of life for young urban Black males and females. Some say that hip-hop culture is not just a reflection of urban reality but it is a creative outlet for young Black people. Whatever the case might be, again Black people need to stop using this hip-hop attitude as a basis for entry into a group or for acceptance.

Black people, we should be confident in the richness of our cultures, even if some of us are coming from predominately white neigborhoods. Coming from a predominately Black neighborhood or country does not make one more in tuned to his or her Blackness either. Let's stop trying to impress one another, because when you go back to your neighborhood that "you go girl" impression dies quickly. And if the impression dies quickly it means it was never a part of you in the first place.

Black people are not the same everywhere even if we share a common plight. We have different stories and experiences to tell, and if you become what the larger Black community wants you to become, you silence yourself and the importance of your experiences. Black is not just African American; it's Caribbean, it's Latin American, it's Biracial, it's multicultural, etc. Black is many things.

—Olajumoke Ade'ola Tasja Osode '93

Graduation is the Best Revenge

It was not in my plans to be in Providence two extra years, but I am glad things worked out the way they did. God gave me time to gain some perspective, build convictions, and meet a lot of wonderful people. I feel privileged to have known African American members of the Class of 1988—seniors from whom I learned a great deal about community and sacrifice—to members of the Class of 1996—first years with a lot of talent and potential. I cannot wait to see how our community develops over the next couple of years.

Words of advice to those who remain, which I learned the hard way: **screw Brown before Brown screws you**. If you feel like Brown is not a supportive environment which wants a young African American to succeed, get the best revenge: **GRADUATE**. Even in the face of academic dismissal, you can always come back and make the picture-perfect finish.

Let that focus include a sense of commitment to the community—not just to Brown, but to Providence. As it gets harder to finance a college education and the world's temptations get harder to resist, fewer of us are going to college. As college students we find ourselves in a position of privilege as African Americans did in the early part of the century. **Let's lift as we climb.**

I would like to say "peace" to my "Brown Sisters United": to Kehli Harding '94, Nadirah Moreland '94, and Lynette Sumpter '94; to other positive folks who encouraged me, like Heather Grady '94, Joelle Murchison '95, Michele Pierre-Louis '95...the list goes on!

But lastly, thank you to the Black community for making my Brown experience all that it was.

Much love and support always,
—Nina Guercio '93

Make Brown Work for You

With graduation just a few days away, the most important lesson I have learned at Brown is: **Make Brown work for you**.

"Brown is full of resources but no one knows about them." How many times have you heard this or some variation of it. Well, you have to take the initiative to find the resources you need to make Brown work for you. For example, say you want to major in "Incognegro," well you should find out who has majored or is majoring in "Incognegro" and ask them which are the best classes and who are the best professors in your major. More seriously, if you want to know all about how OUAP functions, ask any one of the Executive Board members. Even after you graduate you can make Brown work for you.

Some of you may ask, "How can I make Brown work for me if I don't know about its resources?" Good question. Those who have knowledge about resources that could help brothers or sisters in their respective endeavors have a duty to pass on that knowledge; so each one, teach one.

Peace,
—Terrence O. Taylor '93

The Wind Beneath Our Wings

When the angels came to get You,
I couldn't understand why,
But now I've grown to realize
I didn't want to say goodbye.
You're singing Alleluia now,
free from sickness and pain.
I thank God that He gave Me to You—
We are still one in the same.

I always wish that You were here, holding me in Your arms,
but I know You're in a better place now—
still loving Me as time marches on.
I thank God for making You Mine,
even for just a short time.

Our covenat love will always be—a love that is everlasting.

I can't see You in this physical realm, but I feel you everyday,
I am Your walk, talk, laugh—
and yes your smile

You gave me My Wings and You taught Me how to Soar
I am with You, just as You are with Me,
forever You and I will continue to be—
a product of God's love, He created US to be:

You for Me
and
Me for You

We thank God for You,
Akili, Christine, and Lollie—
The Wind Beneath Our Wings

With Love on Mother's Day,
Kwame, Heather, and Brickson

To the Black Bourgeoisie at Brown University,
from Another Bougie Black Senior
Reflections of a Black Senior

If you must be in the master's house, you really cannot afford to be sitting on the sofa. You'd better damn well be rearranging the furniture! (Or as Trina Davis '91 would add, why are we in the master's house in any case, we should be building our own house!)

Let me first clarify who I have addressed this piece to. It includes every Black student at Brown University. The immediate response is to wonder at my presumption in assuming that everyone here is necessarily upper middle class. I have not made that assumption, I did not need to. I use the word bourgeoisie by virtue of where we are now—at this very elite, lily-white school on the hill called Brown University, where the annual fee is more than most Black families could ever dream of making. Admittedly caught up in a busy schedule which includes many hours of work-study to make ends meet, one often feels decidedly unprivileged. Yet as difficult as life may seem financially now, we will most likely be at a very different place in ten years than most Black people. An Ivy League diploma opens doors! By virtue of that diploma, the term bourgeoisie applies to every one of us.

I find that we as Black students too rarely acknowledge our privilege. It has been a source of tremendous frustration to me. I have tried (mostly in vain) to communicate this message to my peers and I struggled with writing this piece. My intention is not to undermine the reality of the racism that we experience. We are oppressed right here at Brown University by virtue of our skin color. I certainly am at a much worse place psychologically leaving Brown than when I came in. My self-concept is lower, I think less of myself intellectually. I know that has everything to do with my being Black and being female. My conversations with fellow Black seniors tell me again and again that this is the case. This is an environment that was never meant to include us and still does not. We are reminded of that reality in a million and one ways on a daily basis. Witness the extent to which OUAP had to struggle to simply get a place which we can call our own. Witness Welela Tereffe's eloquent letter to the Brown Daily Herald in which she reminded the Brown community (in no uncertain terms) that contrary to their expectations we are not here to educate them. Witness the struggle to convince the campus that arming the police was fundamentally incompatible with our presence here. Witness the academic anguish which we as Black science students must go through, with few places to turn for help. Witness the miniscule Black representation on the faculty. The list goes on and on. We are not full fledged citizens here, and we should not pretend for a moment that we are.

Yet I maintain that we must find a way to reconcile our disadvantage in the white context with our undeniable advantage in a Black context. I can count the number of times on my fingers (of one hand!) that I have heard Black students in a public forum acknowledge our privilege. I remember deciding that I would not attend the speak-out following the Los Angeles uprisings, because for me it was a farce to pretend that our situation is the same (or even remotely similar) to that of Black people in South Central L.A. It is true that no Black person anywhere is safe from being beaten by the police. But it is also true that the likelihood of this occurrence is much less in suburbia (where most of us will be heading) than it is in South Central L.A. If only for the time that we are at Brown, we do not have to contend with drug dealers on the street corners, or hearing gunshots and helicopters circling overhead. And this is undeniably a privilege. It reeks of hypocrisy and intellectual dishonesty for us to compare ourselves to Rodney King, when in twenty years we will most likely be within the much safer confines of corporate America (or some university, or a law firm or a hospital or any other cushy job for that matter).

There is a larger reason why it is essential that we come to terms with our privilege. When we do otherwise, we avoid recognizing the tremendous obligation to other Black people that comes along with this privilege. We have a responsibility in whatever capacity we find ourselves to work actively and tirelessly to pull other Blacks along with us. I hear too many Blacks bougies with the following sentiment: *I am the only Black to be a partner in this firm, I am a role model. I have worked hard to get here. Why should I take the worries of the larger community on my shoulders?* I would assert exactly the opposite: we cannot afford not to be concerned about the larger community. For as E. Franklin Frazier reminds us in The Black Bourgeoisie, ours is an elusive security. In the minds of white suburbia, we are no less second class citizens then the Blacks who were downcried as "vandals and hoodlums" in South Central L.A. (It was striking that prominent Black leaders were among those most vehemently reprimanding Blacks!) The genius of oppression is that they have convinced us that we have arrived, when we are still second class citizens in a house that is not ours and which we have not even begun to own.

Yet although we have not arrived, we have perhaps gotten our foot in the door. If we must remain in the master's house, we should make sure that we are rearranging the furniture. There are too many people sitting in the sofas (yes, even here at Brown!). It is not enough to live in suburbia, vote Democrat and write an annual check to the NAACP! We must be actively involved in opening up opportunities for other Blacks. For every job we take in the master's house, we should make sure we have brought several other Black people in before we leave. However we would do well to remember Audre Lourde's assertion that the master's house is not easily dismantled with the master's tools. The better alternative is to build our own house. There are tangible ways to do this starting right now. Take for example the '94s who will be looking for jobs next year. Before you join anyone else's business, start your own! If you must join a white business to get some experience, never lose sight of the ultimate objective of starting your own!

The central problem with our community is that we do not own enough; we are continually in the position of asking other people for money. There is a fundamental incompatibility between maintaining our community's interests and using money which is not our own. Imagine how the whole Africa House scenario would have been different if there had been a wealthy Black alumnus who had funded the House. Unfortunately we were in the position of asking the university (yes, the white university!) for money. This has got to stop and we are in a position to help stop it. Start Black businesses, law firms, hospitals, you name it, whatever your field of interest, consider starting your own before you join someone else's. And then hire

Black people. For this is the only place we will ever work where we will not have to compromise our Blackness. We should not let anyone (white or Black) tell us that our aspirations to economic autonomy are impractical. I am convinced that the lack of confidence that has been instilled in us about our own abilities is the greatest single hindrance to our progress. (As Carter G. Woodson wrote so eloquently: "When you determine what a man shall think you do not have to concern yourself with what he will do.") When we as Black people declared that we would have Africa House, regardless of others' disapproval, we were cut down in many quarters for our "brazenness" (lest Blacks ever become too uppity!). I personally believe that this was the best move we ever made. We told ourselves Africa House was a given, and proceeded to get ours!

A final note: The single most important lesson for the Black community this semester is that we should never compromise our autonomy. The struggle for Africa House indicated that only too clearly. We should take some foolish advice. We should never enter into an arrangement with anyone who asks us to compromise our autonomy (and it does not matter what color they are, they could be Black for all I care). We would do well to avoid exchanging one type of oppression for another.

Peace,
—Eleanor Brown '93

F.Y.I.

• Attention Class of 1994: Elections for ONYX officers will be on Sat., May 15, at 6pm in the TWC. If you would like to run for office but can't attend, please contact Evelyn (x5869) or Heather (x6417)

• There is a sign-up sheet in the TWC Staffers Office for anyone who is staying in Providence this summer. Sign-up if you want to be informed about various get-togethers during the summer for students of color.

• The Resource Center is currently hiring people for various coordinating positions. Contact Laura Pierce (x3013) a.s.a.p. if interested.

**** Congratulations to Derria Byrd & Sandra McDaniel ****
***African Sun* Co-editors for 1993-94**

STAFF BOX

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Olu Gittens
Eddie Goveia
Ebony Lee
LaTeisha Mason
Sandra McDaniel

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